

Make an Army memo with AI. Start here.

AI FUNDAMENTALS IN HEALTH CARE
COACHING NOTE · DR. JARED BLACK

You watched me generate an AR 25-50 memo in seconds during class and asked how it's done. Here it is — the simple way first. Do this once and you'll have a clean, compliant MFR tonight.

You don't learn to code.

The AI writes the LaTeX formatting — you mostly copy, paste, and do a little light cleanup. No need to learn it.

You install nothing.

The fast path runs entirely in your web browser. No software, no IT ticket.

About 15 minutes.

That's the first time, while you find the buttons. After that it's about 3 minutes a memo.

Why not just use Word? In Word you fight the exact AR 25-50 margins, fonts, and spacing by hand. This hands that formatting to a tool built for it, so you spend your time on the words — not rebuilding the layout. It won't be flawless on the first click (see the heads-up below), but it gets you most of the way there, fast.

THE FAST PATH — DO THIS TONIGHT

Chat AI → Overleaf

BROWSER ONLY · ~15 MIN FIRST TIME

YOU'LL NEED · Any chat-based AI — [Ask Sage](#) (the DoD-authorized, CUI-approved one), or ChatGPT / Claude / Gemini for non-sensitive memos — and a free [Overleaf](#) account. Plus the attached **STARTER KIT** (a zip — just unzip it).

For sensitive (CUI) memos, use [asksage.ai](#) (Army CAC users sign in at [chat.genai.army.mil](#)). For routine memos, any chatbot you already have works.

PART A · WRITE IT (IN THE CHAT)

- 1 Unzip the starter kit. (Nothing goes to the AI — you'll only upload two files to Overleaf later.)
- 2 Open your AI (Ask Sage, ChatGPT, Claude...) and start a new chat. Pick the most capable model offered (the newest one, usually at the top).
- 3 Open `sample-prompt.md` from the kit, copy the whole thing, and paste it into the chat. The memo format is *built into the prompt* — no file uploads needed.
- 4 Fill the `[brackets]` with your memo facts, then send.
- 5 The AI replies with the LaTeX. Click **Copy** — but copy **only the code**: it must start with `\documentclass`. Delete any ````` lines or sentences it adds.

PART B · GET THE PDF (OVERLEAF)

- 1 Go to [overleaf.com](#) → sign up free → **New Project** → Blank Project.
- 2 Click **Upload** and add `armymemo.cls` and `D0Db1.pdf` from the kit.
- 3 Paste the copied LaTeX into the main file (replace what's there).
- 4 **Important:** **Menu** → **Compiler** → **LuaLaTeX** (not the default). Click **Recompile**.
- 5 Click **Download PDF**. That's your memo.
- 6 **Blanks?** Anywhere the AI lacked a fact shows an underline. Find the matching `\rule{...}` in the source, type your text over it, Recompile.

Heads up — expect a little fiddling. This is AI + LaTeX, not a one-click button. The first time, plan on some trial and error: sometimes the AI wraps its answer in ````` marks or adds a sentence (delete those); now and then it returns code that won't compile (paste the error message back into the chat and ask it to fix it); and you'll tweak wording and fill in blanks before it's right. It's still far faster than formatting by hand.

Two non-negotiables — these matter more than any step above

1. Mind where the words go. Ask Sage is a government, CUI-approved system — fine for sensitive memo content. **Overleaf and commercial chatbots are not.** Never paste CUI, PHI, or real PII into them. **If your memo contains CUI, skip Overleaf** — compile it on your own computer instead (see the back), so nothing leaves your machine.

2. You sign it, you own it. AI invents names, dates, and regulation numbers with total confidence — a wrong reg number looks exactly as authoritative as a right one. The sample prompt tells it to leave blanks instead of guessing. Read every line before it goes out; "the AI wrote it" is not a defense.

OPTIONAL

The fast path above is a complete, permanent solution — many people never need more. If you make memos often, here are two setups that remove the copy-paste. Skip this page until you want it.

First, what you were actually doing. That “block of code” is **LaTeX** (say “LAY-tek”), a typesetting system. A *compiler* turns it into the finished PDF — that’s what Overleaf did. The formatting all comes from the class file `armymemo.cls`: it encodes the AR 25-50 rules, so you and the AI supply the words and it handles the layout. The two upgrades below just move the writing and the compiling onto your own computer so there’s no carrying files between two websites.

TWO FASTER SETUPS

Claude Cowork

DESKTOP AGENT · WRITES THE FILE FOR YOU

Need: the [Claude desktop app](#) ([Cowork](#), on any paid plan — Pro or higher).

- Put the starter-kit folder in your Documents folder.
- Open the app, click **Cowork**, point it at that folder, grant access.
- Tell it: “Using the armymemo template here, write an MFR about [your facts]. Save it as a new .tex file. Don’t make anything up — leave blanks.”
- It writes the file for you. For the PDF, hand the file to Overleaf, or compile locally if you’ve installed LaTeX (see below).

Claude Code in VS Code

THE WAY I DO IT IN CLASS · MOST SETUP, LEAST EFFORT AFTER

Need: VS Code, [Claude Code](#), and LaTeX installed (below). One-time setup; then it’s the fastest.

- Open a folder containing `armymemo.cls` + `D0Db1.pdf` in VS Code; start Claude Code.
- Ask in plain English: “Using armymemo.cls here, write an MFR about [facts], leave blanks for anything missing, then compile twice with lualatex and open the PDF.”
- It writes the memo, compiles it, and opens the PDF — no copy-paste, and nothing leaves your machine.
- Iterate by talking. (In class I use a custom `/memo` skill that also auto-loads the regs — [AR 25-50](#), the [Tongue & Quill](#) — you can build one once you’re comfortable.)

COMPILING ON YOUR OWN COMPUTER (NEEDED FOR BOTH UPGRADES, AND FOR ANY CUI MEMO)

Install [MacTeX](#) ([tug.org/mactex](#), for Mac) or [TeX Live](#) ([tug.org/texlive](#), for Windows/Linux) — one time, a few GB. Then keep `armymemo.cls` and `D0Db1.pdf` in the same folder as your `.tex` file and run, twice, in a terminal: `lualatex memo.tex && lualatex memo.tex`. The PDF appears next to the file. Because it’s all on your machine, this path is safe for CUI. (The memo uses Times New Roman + Arial; Mac and Overleaf have them, a bare Linux box may need the `msttcorefonts` package first.)

WHICH IS WHICH

METHOD	SETUP	EFFORT PER MEMO	STAYS ON YOUR COMPUTER?	BEST FOR
Chat AI → Overleaf	None — browser only	~3 min (copy-paste)	No — uses Overleaf	Everyone’s starting point; all most people need
Claude Cowork	Desktop app, paid plan	~2 min, no copy-paste	Writing yes; PDF if LaTeX installed	Frequent memos, non-technical
Claude Code	Most — app + LaTeX	Fastest — one line	Yes — fully local (CUI-safe)	Power users; sensitive content

WHAT’S IN THE STARTER KIT (ATTACHED ZIP)

- `sample-prompt.md` — the ready-to-paste prompt for Part A (no uploads).
- `D0Db1.pdf` — the DoD seal. Upload to Overleaf too.
- `mfr-template.tex` — a blank fill-in memo, if you’d rather start by hand.
- `digsig.sty` — optional; ignore unless you add a digital signature.

- `armymemo.cls` — the rulebook (all AR 25-50 formatting). Upload to Overleaf.
- `mfr-template-EXAMPLE-output.pdf` — what a finished memo looks like.
- `README.txt` — the same steps, in the folder.

Bottom line: do the fast path first — once you’ve found the buttons, you’ll have a compliant MFR in about 15 minutes, and you never have to touch the other two methods unless you want to go faster. — Dr. Jared Black